in a cabinet meeting for speaking out of turn. Another stress-mark: postings given to some senior police officers during large-scale transfers in October-November were either stayed or amended. (Fadnavis holds the home portfolio.)

The Congress leader claims Fadnavis is "sulking" at being forced to play second fiddle to Shinde, who was a minister under him in 2014-19. "He may be trying to show Shinde can't run the state efficiently." Senior journalist Sandeep Pradhan recalls a spate of leaks during Fadnavis's tenure as CM against BJP ministers seen to be on his wrong side: Eknath Khadse, Vinod Tawde, Pankaja Munde, Chandrakant Patil and Prakash Mehta.

On the expansion, Shinde also risks facing dissent from those left out. A BJP leader seconds that. "Shinde is facing a problem of plenty. There are too many contenders with nuisance value in his camp. They may not settle for positions in state-run corporations... the BJP may have to concede some more ground to Shinde," he says. And as a senior BJP MLA admits, restiveness is not unique to the Shinde camp. "Some powerful Congress-NCP leaders joined the BJP for better prospects. They want to be ministers. Old-timers here are feeling overlooked." ■

ASSAM/ DELIMITATION

# SHIFTING THE LINES




**By Kaushik Deka**

From the very first day of 2023, the Election Commission of India (ECI) has initiated the delimitation of assembly and parliamentary constituencies in Assam. The exercise, as mandated by Article 170 of the Constitution and the Representation of the People Act (RPA), 1950, redraws boundaries of legislative constituencies to reflect changes in population. It also reworks the number of seats reserved for scheduled castes and tribes, as provisioned by Articles 330 and 332 of the Constitution. The objective is to provide fair representation to all.

While Assam chief minister Himanta Biswa Sarma has claimed that the delimitation process would "safeguard Assam's future", Opposition parties have questioned the timing and intent of the exercise. Some have even dubbed it as a conspiracy to deny Muslims their political rights, as the ECI will use 2001 Census data for delimitation, though 2011 Census data is available. The Muslim population in Assam grew from 29 per cent in 2001 to 34 per cent in 2011. Government sources say that the current delimitation is being done under the Delimitation Act of 2002, which mandates 2001 Census data as the base for constituency demarcation.

As per the Constitution, delimitation should be conducted after every Census to account for demographic changes. It mandates that the number of Lok Sabha seats allotted to a state should be such that the ratio between that number and the state's population is, as far as practical, the same for all states. Accordingly, there have been four previous delimitations, the last being in 1976 (based on 1971 Census).



MANASH DAS

**CENTRE OF DEVOTION** Holi celebrations in the Barpeta Satra in Barpeta district, Assam

However, delimitation based on population meant that states with no population control could end up with a greater number of seats in Parliament. To allay the fear of unequal political representation expressed by developed states, the Constitution was amended in 1976 to suspend delimitation until 2001. Another amendment in 2001 postponed this till 2026. However, in 2002, a new Delimitation Act was passed to redraw the existing number of parliamentary/ assembly constituencies on the basis of the 2001 Census. But the